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BOXING

BHIWANI'S AFFINITY TO THE GAME OF BOXING IS THE RESULT OF A COMBINATION OF INSPIRATION: HOME-GROWN CHAMPIONS, RICH DIET AND DEDICATED COACHES



EARLY BIRDS: Local boxing centres in Bhiwani enroll the boys between 10 and 14 years of age

level within three years. Most of the inductees are born-tough rural lads who think nothing of the harsh training and rudimentary facilities they may have to face. They all have examples of iron-willed boxers around them, like Parvinder Singh who went from a jaw fracture in 2002 to fighting for India in the Commonwealth Games in 2006. Ten-year-old Sunil, one of the youngest trainees in SAI, says, "A bloody-nose never scares me. It only steels my determination to be a champion."

What makes Bhiwani's feat even more extraordinary is that its infrastructure could be classified as very ordinary: two years ago, worn-out rings and tattered gunny bags acting as punching bags, were the only aids

available. "The lack of facilities has actually been a blessing in disguise," says Jagdish, adding that it helped in making the training more rigorous. His coaching centre is a sun-scorched shed topped by a tin-roof where the boys use a hand pump to draw water. Their regimen involves desert running in the countryside twice a week and they are encouraged to box without chin guards, a method, coaches say, teaches boxers among others to be both skillful and tough.

Vijender, a 2006 Asian Games medallist, comes from Kaluwas, known as the 'village of boxers', and is getting ready for his Olympic debut. He explains Bhiwani's affinity for boxing as a "combination of inspiration":

home-grown champions, rich diet and dedicated coaches. He jokes, "The old saying '*doodh dahi ka khana, ehi mera Haryana*' (It's a diet of milk and curd, that's my Haryana) still holds good in our part of the state."

An over-riding motivation for boxers are job opportunities that come with sporting success. In the last decade, it is believed more than 500 boxers from Bhiwani have landed jobs with the army, para-military forces, the railways and the police. "A job is the first motivation for anyone taking up the gloves," adds Akhil. Already employed with the Indian Railways, Akhil, Vijender and Jitender have now been offered jobs as inspectors in the Haryana Police. "Experience is the biggest guru in boxing," says the feisty Akhil, who will delay joining the Haryana police in order to keep his mind on his training.

Bhiwani's boxing exploits have now caught the attention of sports administrators and private organisations. In 2006, the SAI recognised the town's potential as a training centre and ramped up the infrastructure, importing a Rs 10-lakh ring from overseas. The SAI has set the ball rolling on a proposal to set up an exclusive 200-bedded boxing centre on a 10-acre plot provided by the state government.

"The underlying idea is to make Bhiwani an assembly line of boxing champions," says Roy. The Mittal Champions Trust—run by steel tycoon Lakshmi Niwas Mittal—is already funding local boxers for their diet, equipment and foreign training, helping significantly in the medical rehabilitation of Akhil and Dinesh.

Today though all eyes are on the Bhiwani quartet going to Beijing. "I have never seen such a highly motivated bunch of the Indian boxers," says Sandhu. Clearly, Bhiwani is looking forward with barely suppressed excitement to Beijing and the Olympics. The boxing ring could bring to this nondescript town its ultimate glory. ■